

Sowing the Seeds of Sustainability: How the smallest partnerships can grow successful college-based transition programs

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Why I do this work

- In 1996, I was working on my dissertation and conducting research on cross cultural comparisons of educational outcomes for marginalized populations in countries where education was a constitutional right.
- In 1997, I became a mom to my son who was ultimately diagnosed with a genetic disorder and autism.
- I left my graduate program and the workforce to care for my son and was unable to return to work until he was in middle school.
- Out of my research and lived experiences, I firmly believe that the opportunity to pursue college and career interests should be a right afforded to **ALL**.



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A Brief History of Our Program



- MMI received a Think College mini grant in January 2018.
- We partnered with the University of Nebraska-Omaha and enrolled our first student in a pilot program in August 2018.
- We enrolled our first cohort of three students in August 2019.
- To increase college readiness, we created the College and Career Exploration Program in August 2019 with 3 area school districts.
- The Advocacy and the Arts Program was started in July 2020.
- Our first two students graduated in May 2021 and are working 20+ hours per week.
- In partnership with the Trailblazer Program, the UNO Unified Program was started in May 2021
- The Career and Work-Based Learning Program started in August 2021.



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The MMI-UNO Trailblazer Program

Like many programs, the Trailblazer Program is a two-year certificate program for students with IDD, and it is a partnership between the Munroe-Meyer Institute's UCEDD and the University of Nebraska-Omaha

Each semester students complete the following:

1. Minimum of two undergraduate **courses** (determined by student interest)
 - **6-7 hours/week** – attending class
 - **3-6 hours/week** – tutoring and enrichment
2. **Work experience:** Students explore interests and possibilities; job rotations and training
 - **2-6 hours/week**
3. **Social opportunities:** Including meals, physical activity, events, and clubs
 - **4-8 hours/week**
4. **Individual instruction:** Provided by peer mentors and program staff to meet goals as planned for each student
 - **1-4 hours/week**



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A Few Advantages for Our Sustainability

- We received a \$20,000 Think College mini-grant to support development in 2018
- We had key leadership initiatives for cross-campus collaboration
- Core staff salaries are covered by UCEDD funding
 - .3 to .5 FTE of director's salary covered by UCEDD
 - Employment Liaison's salary covered by UCEDD
 - .5 FTE of the certified teacher's salary is covered for **the first year**



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Location Matters!

- We are housed in the Community Engagement Center (CEC) in the center of campus with 35 other non-profit organizations and student groups.
- We have access to interns that work for 10 hours per week at no cost to our program.
- We have access to the Service Learning Academy that partners with our students on disability advocacy, provides access to free PR assistance each semester, and course collaborations (disability art).
- UNO sponsors seven days of service events throughout the year to give student volunteers a chance to engage in service projects around the community.
- We recently formed a Unified Program with Special Olympics—this covers liability to off campus social events!



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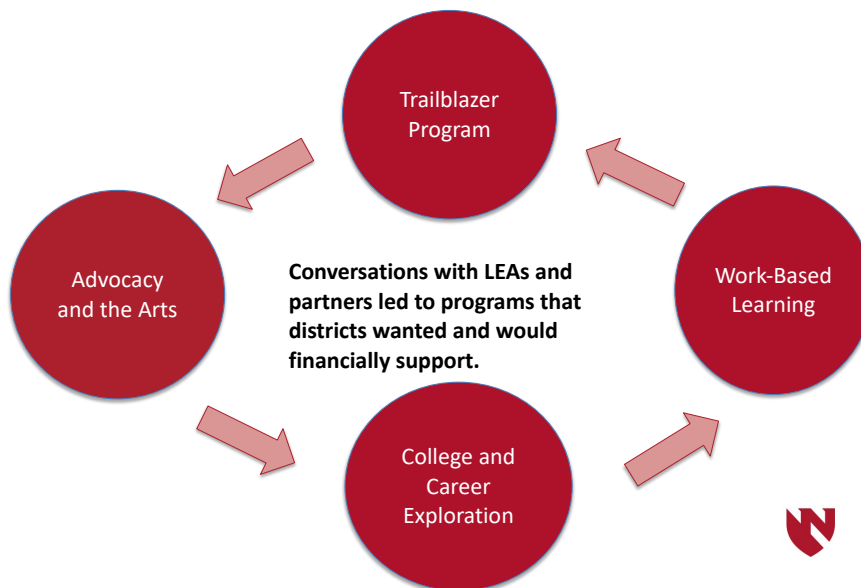
Small Conversations Can Lead to Big Things

- We partnered with community organizations to braid funding and resources.
 - The UCEDD provided \$6,000 to cover the cost of staff and materials for a summer transition program + \$6,000 was provided by an arts organization for weekly arts workshops during the school year.
 - This led to a \$50,000 annual donation to support arts-based employment programs.
 - This generated a \$2+ million legacy donation (Robert S. Dewaele MMI Preparation for Resilience and Achievement Fund) to support arts and employment opportunities for individuals with IDD.



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The Trailblazer Programs



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Conversations Continued

- Three schools joined our weekly arts programming at UNO
 - Districts provided transportation and support staff for 4 students, and we provided the program at no cost to district
- We recognized students needed opportunities to prepare for college based upon feedback from districts and families
 - We started the College and Career Exploration Program
 - Districts provided transportation and support staff for 4 students, and we provided the program at no cost to districts
- This model allowed for districts to see the benefits of their students on a college campus and opened dialogues for continued collaborations.
- We developed a feeder program for successful candidates.



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Department of Education Approval

- Districts approached us to become an approved education service agency.
- MMI is already an approved DoE service agency for other services.
- For transition services to be approved, **DoE required a certified teacher to be on staff.**
- We submitted rates to the NE DoE based upon our costs and not their approved rates.
- Once a certified teacher was hired, The Department of Education approved our rates.
- MMI bills districts monthly; school districts submit for reimbursement to the DoE.



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Requirements for School Contracts with NE Department of Education Rate Approval

- A certified teacher with proper endorsements must be on staff.
 - Minimum Requirement: Special Education Generalist, 7-12
 - Preferred: Secondary Transition Specialist, 7-12
- A teacher can seek a provisional license.
 - A teacher with a K-6 license can apply for a provisional license and set a plan to complete necessary coursework for 7-12 certification within 2 years
- Quarterly progress reports must be submitted to district.



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MPS & MMI 2021-2022 School Year Contract
10/1/2021 - 5/31/2022

Approved
NE DoE Rates

Services	Rate/hr	Hours/wk	Weeks	Total Hours	Total Cost
Program Supervisor	\$77.30	5	30	150	\$ 11,595
Program Consultant/Certified Teacher	\$70.86	20	30	600	\$ 42,516
Paraprofessional	\$18.00	30	30	900	\$ 16,200
Subtotal					\$ 70,311
Admin Fee (10%)					\$ 7,031
Total Cost for Provider Services					\$ 77,342
Total Monthly (8)					\$ 9,668

Cost for MMI Business
office to manage contract



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Things to Consider with College-Based Transition Services

What does the district want for hours?

- We could not accommodate for 6 hours per day for a large volume of students

We have two Trailblazer students that are dually enrolled in a school district's transition program and are on campus full days.

- This was a heavy lift for staff coverage in the beginning.

Districts may not want the BEST program—they will settle for appropriate every time, and this can cause tension for staff on both sides and for families.

- Be prepared for calls from parents wondering how to get their child "in" to your transition programming.

A student may be ready for employment or other activities, but districts are not ready for reduced hours for the student or growth.

- "Scope of practice" became a common phrase.



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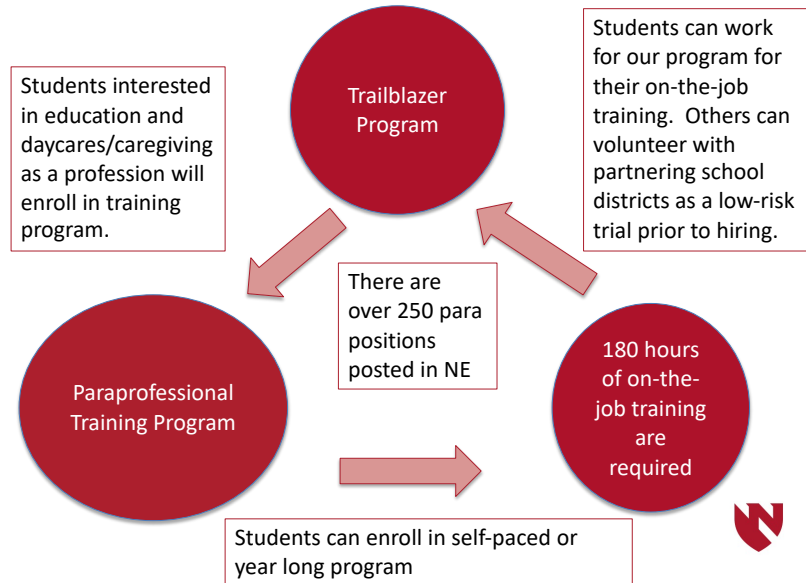
Current Conversations

- We are in discussions with the NE Department of Labor and are applying to become an Eligible Training Provider to support our Work-Based Training programs and internships.
- Our first program seeking approval is a paraprofessional training program to meet the needs of our students interested in working within schools and daycare settings.
- We have been approved to be a Project Para Training Program from the University of Nebraska's Department of Education and the site that certifies successful completion of the program.
- We will also serve parents or family members of individuals with disabilities in this program.
 - Increases an inclusive setting
 - Increases funding
 - We will be reimbursed \$6,800 for each graduate.



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Work-Based Learning Model



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| Any
Questions?



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